

ERIC SCHMALZBAUER

Former co-founder & CEO, Prospective

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WHEN • TENTATIVELY SCHEDULED

SESSION 2

MON, SEPT 14 • 12:30 PM ET

FORMAT

FIRESIDE CHAT

MODERATED, THEN QUESTIONS

LENGTH

30 MINUTES

VIRTUAL

YOUR TITLE

B2B: from idea > funding > failure

DEFAULT EVENT COPY

This is what we will publish on the event page.
If you would like it adjusted, send us the revisions.

ABOUT THIS SESSION

Founders hear success stories constantly and almost never a first-hand account of the other outcome. Eric Schmalzbauer walks the whole arc of his venture-backed B2B startup as a first-time founder: the idea, the fundraising, building the team, and when and why to close up shop, then what he will change for his next business and what he will do more of. Whatever stage you are at the same problems show up, raising money, building a team, getting to market, managing investors. Expect a candid conversation rather than a polished talk.

TAKEAWAYS

- Tangible examples of what worked and what did not inside a venture-backed startup
- As a founder, you always have to be selling, in some form
- Honest acknowledgement that the job is very lonely

WHO IT IS FOR

Any founder in the cohort. Whatever stage you are at, the same problems show up: raising money, building a team, getting to market, and managing investors.

ABOUT ERIC

Eric Schmalzbauer is a technology executive, founder, and venture partner across product strategy, data platforms, and go-to-market execution. He is the now former co-Founder and CEO of Prospective, the team behind the open-source Perspective project, building high-performance tools for interactive data analytics. Eric previously held senior leadership roles across financial market infrastructure and enterprise technology. As a Venture Partner at REFASHIOND Ventures, he advises early-stage founders on product-market fit, fundraising, and scaling.

A RESOURCE ERIC RECOMMENDS

The Workbench Ventures GTM Weekly newsletter, workbench.substack.com/s/gtm-weekly

WHAT'S NEXT

Calendar hold	For the educational session only. Lands as soon as you confirm the date.
Sync call	Book a prep call for the week before, whatever time works for you: calendly.com/mj-techunited/30min
Your 30 minutes	A 20 to 25 minute moderated conversation, then questions from founders at the end. We hold the clock.

STEVE CUMMINS

Principal / Chief Marketer, Solent Strategies

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WHEN • TENTATIVELY SCHEDULED

SESSION 4

FRI, SEPT 18 • 12:30 PM ET

FORMAT

PRESENTATION*
WITH SLIDES, THEN Q&A

LENGTH

30 MINUTES
VIRTUAL

YOUR TITLE

Marketing that Maps the Customer Journey

DEFAULT EVENT COPY

This is what we will publish on the event page.
If you would like it adjusted, send us the revisions.

ABOUT THIS SESSION

Every founder is told to do marketing, and everyone they ask has a different opinion. Steve Cummins, a fractional CMO with more than 20 years in B2B marketing, starts from the classic marketing funnel and shows which tactics belong at which stage, then makes the case that the customer journey is no longer linear and needs a more nuanced read. The session closes on the one or two things worth doing well rather than covering every base.

TAKEAWAYS

- Define the goal of your marketing, then match tactics to each stage
- What has to be in place before you spend: a clear message, a defined reachable audience
- Do one or two things well rather than covering every base

WHO IT IS FOR

Founders who are pre-revenue and testing the market, already generating revenue, or raising. Useful to anyone who knows they should be marketing and has neither the time nor the budget to do all of it.

ABOUT STEVE

Steve helps growing businesses punch above their weight, working with companies who are ready to take marketing seriously but are not ready for a full time CMO. That means developing the right message, reaching a broader audience, and executing a marketing plan tailored for their business. Steve has an engineering background and more than 20 years experience in global B2B marketing with name-brand companies and feisty start-ups. He also coaches and mentors marketers and teams of one.

A RESOURCE STEVE RECOMMENDS

A one-pager built for this session, plus an 8-page eBook, Building a Realistic Marketing Strategy.

WHAT'S NEXT

Calendar hold

For the educational session only. Lands as soon as you confirm the date.

Sync call

Book a prep call for the week before, whatever time works for you: calendly.com/mj-techunited/30min

Your 30 minutes

Roughly 20 minutes of content, then questions. We hold the clock.

**Slides only. If you are presenting, the final deck is due 72 hours before the session.*

SHEILISA MCNEAL

Founder & CEO, Fria Inc.

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WHEN • TENTATIVELY SCHEDULED

SESSION 5
MON, SEPT 21 • 12:30 PM ET

FORMAT

PRESENTATION*
WITH SLIDES, THEN Q&A

LENGTH

30 MINUTES
VIRTUAL

YOUR TITLE

Is venture funding the right capital for your business?

DEFAULT EVENT COPY

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If you would like it adjusted, send us the revisions.

ABOUT THIS SESSION

Venture capital gets treated as the default answer to how you fund a company, and plenty of founders read their first term sheet only once it is in front of them. Sheilisa McNeal works the decision itself: whether your model, growth goals and exit expectations fit venture, or whether grants, revenue, loans, partnerships or angel money fit better. Then what you exchange for the money, and the provisions that quietly decide how much of the company you still steer afterwards.

TAKEAWAYS

- Assess venture fit: whether your model, growth goals and exit expectations suit venture, or grants, revenue, loans, partnerships or angels
- Know the tradeoffs: equity, dilution, board influence, investor rights, pressure for rapid growth
- Read a term sheet before you sign: valuation, liquidation preferences, voting rights, board seats, pro rata, option pools, exclusivity

WHO IT IS FOR

Founders raising or about to raise, founders already generating revenue, and anyone who wants to understand how investors think.

ABOUT SHEILISA

Sheilisa McNeal is an inventor and the Founder and CEO of Fria Inc., a health-tech company developing wearable cooling accessories for vasomotor discomfort. Guided by the belief that problems just require solutions, she turned cooling jewels from an idea into an IP-protected, revenue-generating startup recognized by the NSF SBIR program and the New Jersey Commission on Science, Innovation and Technology. She also brings deep experience in communications and marketing strategy, including service as an adjunct lecturer at NYU's School of Professional Studies.

A RESOURCE SHEILISA RECOMMENDS

A plain-language glossary of the terms in a term sheet, from valuation and dilution through liquidation preference, option pools, pro rata rights, SAFEs and no-shop provisions.

WHAT'S NEXT

The three-part version

You offered to run this across funding fit, tradeoffs and term-sheet readiness. We want it. We will hold dates two and three on the sync call.

Sync call

Book a prep call for the week before, whatever time works for you: calendly.com/mj-techunited/30min

Your 30 minutes

Roughly 20 minutes of content, then questions. We hold the clock.

**Slides only. If you are presenting, the final deck is due 72 hours before the session.*

JEANNE MCPHILLIPS

Professor of Business Innovation, SCAD • Founder, SuperGirls

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WHEN • TENTATIVELY SCHEDULED

SESSION 6

TUE, SEPT 22 • 5:30 PM ET

FORMAT

WORKING SESSION

YOU BRING WORK, COACHED LIVE

LENGTH

60 MINUTES

VIRTUAL

YOUR TITLE

Brand Positioning & Story-First Marketing: Building a Brand People Remember (Without a Big Budget)

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ABOUT THIS SESSION

Most early-stage founders think of marketing as something to tackle once the product is built and the funding is secured, which is exactly when the visibility they needed a year ago would have paid. Jeanne McPhillips runs this as a working session on a practical framework: define a clear, differentiated brand position, turn your founder story into a repeatable marketing and PR asset, and build a lean content and earned-media strategy that creates visibility before there is a budget for it. Founders leave with something written down rather than a set of principles. This one runs a full hour.

TAKEAWAYS

- A brand framework you can reuse
- A positioning statement, written in the room
- A 90-day content and PR plan you can start on Monday

WHO IT IS FOR

Any founder in the cohort. Built for people who need visibility now and have no marketing budget to buy it.

ABOUT JEANNE

Jeanne McPhillips is a fractional CMO and brand strategist who helps founders turn a raw idea into a brand people remember. She founded SuperGirls and created Bold Future Leadership, a cohort program for women creative leaders, and teaches the marketing and business curriculum at SCAD. She hosts the podcast Pink Balls and wrote Be Your Own Hero. She is also a mentor in this fall's Uplift cohort.

A RESOURCE JEANNE RECOMMENDS

Three things founders keep: a brand framework, a positioning statement template, and a content plan.

WHAT'S NEXT

You get the full hour

You said this works best at 60 minutes with breakouts. Two of the three dates you picked were Tuesday evenings, and those are the ones we can run long, so we moved you to Tue Sept 22 at 5:30 and gave you the whole hour. Nothing needs cutting.

Sync call

Book a prep call for the week before, whatever time works for you: calendly.com/mj-techunited/30min

Your 60 minutes

Room for the framework, the live positioning exercise and the breakouts as you designed them. We have your Canva deck; if it changes, the final version is due 72 hours before. We hold the clock.

KENNETH JONES

Independent builder · Uplift mentor, Summer 2026

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WHEN · TENTATIVELY SCHEDULED

SESSION 7
FRI, SEPT 25 · 12:30 PM ET

FORMAT

WORKING SESSION
YOU BRING WORK, COACHED LIVE

LENGTH

30 MINUTES
VIRTUAL

YOUR TITLE

Vibe coding: what is this and how can it help you?

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ABOUT THIS SESSION

Founders keep hitting the same wall: the tool the business needs does not exist, and paying someone to build it is out of reach. Kenneth Jones opens with what AI-assisted vibe coding actually is and walks the working applications he has built on Replit, live. Founders leave with homework: write the requirements for something your own business needs. That becomes the raw material for parts two and three.

TAKEAWAYS

- How to write business requirements for an application
- Where AI and vibe coding realistically help a business, and where they do not
- How to get running in Replit, including the options, costs and setup

WHO IT IS FOR

Any founder in the cohort, idea stage through raising. No coding background assumed.

ABOUT KENNETH

Kenneth Jones has spent his career in technology management, with a long-running interest in applications development, business and economic news, and artificial intelligence. He now builds and ships his own AI-assisted applications, with more in the pipeline. He is a former college professor and conference education co-chair, a TiE mentor, and mentored two Uplift founders in Summer 2026.

A RESOURCE KENNETH RECOMMENDS

His Replit hub at kenjonesnj.com, with links to every application he has built. Those are the teaching examples for the series.

WHAT'S NEXT

About this date

This was your second pick. You mentioned a Friday engagement might be landing, so if it does, tell us and we will move you to a Monday.

The series

You proposed three sessions two weeks apart: intro and demos, then a working session on founders' ideas, then founder demos. We want all three. Sessions 7, 14 and 20 hold that spacing: Sept 25, Oct 12, Oct 23.

Sync call

Book a prep call for the week before, whatever time works for you: calendly.com/mj-techunited/30min

Your 30 minutes

Roughly 20 minutes of content and live demo, then questions. We hold the clock and set the homework at the end.

JULIA KAHKY

VP Operations, Tailsight

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WHEN • TENTATIVELY SCHEDULED

SESSION 8
MON, SEPT 28 • 12:30 PM ET

FORMAT

PRESENTATION*
WITH SLIDES, THEN Q&A

LENGTH

30 MINUTES
VIRTUAL

YOUR TITLE

From startup to dissolution: a post-mortem

DEFAULT EVENT COPY

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ABOUT THIS SESSION

Everything online talks about how companies succeed, when founders learn far more from avoiding the mistakes of companies that failed. Julia Kahky walks the post-mortem of a startup that closed, specifically what she learned trying to sell software to enterprise customers and into highly regulated markets: what worked, what did not, the problems worth avoiding early, and how long sales cycles really take.

TAKEAWAYS

- Problems to avoid early on
- Product-market fit
- Sales cycles

WHO IT IS FOR

Founders at any stage, from idea through raising, and anyone selling into enterprise or regulated buyers where cycles are long and requirements arrive late.

ABOUT JULIA

Julia Kahky is VP of Operations at a software company in the aviation industry, with prior experience as a chief of staff and in financial technology and operations in sports media. She started her career in finance and has worked across Fortune 15 companies, 500-person companies, and startups, with experience spanning finance, operations, marketing, revenue operations, and HR.

A RESOURCE JULIA RECOMMENDS

The Atrium, a founder community, plus a working list of AI tools, tips and tricks.

WHAT'S NEXT

Calendar hold

For the educational session only. Lands as soon as you confirm the date.

Sync call

Book a prep call for the week before, whatever time works for you: calendly.com/mj-techunited/30min

Your 30 minutes

Roughly 20 minutes of content, then questions. We hold the clock.

**Slides only. If you are presenting, the final deck is due 72 hours before the session.*

ASHLEY RYDER

Partner, VamosVentures

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WHEN • TENTATIVELY SCHEDULED

SESSION 10

FRI, OCT 2 • 12:30 PM ET

FORMAT

FIRESIDE CHAT

MODERATED, THEN QUESTIONS

LENGTH

30 MINUTES

VIRTUAL

YOUR TITLE

Fundraising AMA

OUR SUGGESTION

So founders know what they are walking into:

Fundraising AMA: ask an early-stage VC

anything. Moderated, and open book, so nothing is off the table.

DEFAULT EVENT COPY

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ABOUT THIS SESSION

Fundraising is a black hole. Founders guess at what investors want, and the people who could tell them straight are the same people they are pitching. Ashley Ryder, a Partner at the early-stage fund VamosVentures, gives the cohort the reverse: a session that is nothing but questions, on preparing to raise, on building a strategy rather than a list of intros, and on the question sitting underneath both, whether venture dollars are the right money for your company at all. Bring the question you have not been able to get answered anywhere else.

TAKEAWAYS

- What to have in place before you start raising
- How to build a fundraising strategy rather than a list of intros
- A straight read on whether you should take VC dollars

WHO IT IS FOR

Any founder in the cohort. Most useful if you are raising, about to raise, or still deciding whether to.

ABOUT ASHLEY

Ashley Ryder is a Partner at VamosVentures, an early-stage fund investing in diverse teams across healthcare, fintech, future of work and sustainability, where she has led deals including Fundamental Research Labs, Clarity Pediatrics and Handspring Health. She began her career at Morgan Stanley in capital markets, moved into operating roles at a Y Combinator startup and Fortune 500 companies, and has invested at Brand Foundry Ventures, Founders Factory and Dorm Room Fund. She is driven by the conviction that investing in overlooked founders is financially astute as well as socially imperative. She holds a B.A. from Brown and an MBA from MIT Sloan.

WHAT'S NEXT

About this date

Your first choice, Session 1, falls this Friday, too close now to give the event page a proper run-up. Friday Oct 2 at 12:30 was your second choice.

Sync call

Book a prep call for the week before, whatever time works for you: calendly.com/mj-techunited/30min

Your 30 minutes

An AMA, so we open the floor early rather than at the end. We will seed the first questions, collect more from founders beforehand, moderate, and hold the clock. Nothing for you to prepare.

JARON RUBENSTEIN

Technical CEO & Fractional CTO, Rubenstein Ventures

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WHEN • BOOKED

SESSION 12
TUE, OCT 6 • 5:30 PM ET

FORMAT

PRESENTATION*
WITH SLIDES, THEN Q&A

LENGTH

30 MINUTES
VIRTUAL

YOUR TITLE

Managing engineers

DEFAULT EVENT COPY

This is what we will publish on the event page.
If you would like it adjusted, send us the revisions.

ABOUT THIS SESSION

Most founders leading an engineering team have never been engineers themselves. Jaron Rubenstein calls that the number one internal challenge facing the non-technical founders he works with, and one that can easily be the difference between a startup succeeding and failing. He covers the most important things a non-technical founder should know when managing and growing an engineering team: how to communicate with the engineers you have, what to look for in the ones you hire next, and how to use AI to get more technical output with less frustration on both sides.

TAKEAWAYS

- How to better communicate with your engineering team
- What to look for when recruiting and hiring engineers
- Using AI to maximize your technical output and minimize engineering frustration

WHO IT IS FOR

Any founder in the cohort, and non-technical founders above all: anyone who is managing, hiring or about to hire engineers.

ABOUT JARON

Jaron Rubenstein is a digital marketing technology innovator, strategist, software engineer and business leader, with deep operational, marketing and data security expertise in professional services organizations. He is the founder and former CEO of RubyLaw, a legal marketing technology SaaS platform, where he set the strategic vision, led the technology strategy, and grew the company to a 20% market share of the Am Law 200 before leading an M&A process that culminated in an acquisition in 2023. As a fractional CTO he now guides startups and teams designing and building the next generation of AI-centered software. Jaron is also a Founder Coach with the Robin Hood Foundation's Blue Ridge Labs venture studio, mentoring tech-driven founders tackling the most pressing social issues for underserved NYC communities.

WHAT JARON WILL HAND THE COHORT

Details, tips, tricks, and actual AI prompts and workflows to use.

WHAT'S NEXT

Your date Tuesday Oct 6 at 5:30, one of the three you picked. Monday Oct 19 had gone before your application reached us.

Sync call Book a prep call for the week before, whatever time works for you: calendly.com/mj-techunited/30min

Your 30 minutes Roughly 20 to 25 minutes of slides, then questions from founders. We hold the clock.

** Slides only. If you are presenting, the final deck is due 72 hours before the session.*

SHIKHA SONEJI

CEO & Founder, ConsenTerra

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WHEN • TENTATIVELY SCHEDULED

SESSION 13

FRI, OCT 9 • 12:30 PM ET

FORMAT

WORKING SESSION

YOU BRING WORK, BUILT LIVE

LENGTH

30 MINUTES

VIRTUAL

YOUR TITLE

Ship AI that actually works: one real workflow, built live

DEFAULT EVENT COPY

This is what we will publish on the event page.
If you would like it adjusted, send us the revisions.

ABOUT THIS SESSION

Every founder has been told to put AI in the business, and most of the advice stops at the demo. Shikha Soneji runs this as a working session: founders bring a repetitive task from their own company, drafting proposals, triaging leads, answering the same customer questions, and she turns one of them into a reliable AI workflow live in the room. The part most sessions skip gets the time here, which is where the workflow will break and how you catch that before a customer does.

TAKEAWAYS

- How to pick the one task in your business worth automating first, and the ones to leave alone
- A simple prompt plus verification pattern that keeps AI output trustworthy enough to put in front of customers
- Where the workflow will break, and how to catch it before a customer does

WHO IT IS FOR

Any founder in the cohort. Bring a real task from your own business, not a hypothetical. No engineering background needed.

ABOUT SHIKHA

Shikha Soneji is the CEO and founder of ConsenTerra, an AI-native compliance platform for data center operators, covering privacy, environmental and AI regulation for facilities that carry heavy compliance burdens without the legal infrastructure to match. She was named one of the Top 26 Founders of 2026. She holds a PhD in Informatics from Penn State, where her research combined privacy law, machine learning and explainable AI and earned her an award for AI for Social Impact. Before founding ConsenTerra she spent five and a half years as a data scientist at ADP, working on RAG systems, agentic AI and knowledge management. She was selected for the FoundersBoost NYC Spring 2026 cohort and mentors through WIT TCCP.

WHAT'S NEXT

Your other two topics

You sent three and a slot only holds one, so this one is **Ship AI that actually works**. We want **Defining your ICP** and **Pitch without a deck** as their own dates. We will pick them on the call.

About this date

All three dates you picked fell in the first three weeks, and all three have gone. Friday Oct 9 at 12:30 is the same slot shape, with room to promote it properly and to line up founders with real work for you to build. If a different date suits you better, say so.

Sync call

Book a prep call for the week before, whatever time works for you: calendly.com/mj-techunited/30min

Your 30 minutes

A short setup, then one founder's real task built end to end while the room watches. We will line up two volunteers in advance so it does not stall. We hold the clock.

JONATHAN HAKAKIAN

Managing Director & Co-founder, SoundBoard Venture Fund

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WHEN • TENTATIVELY SCHEDULED

SESSION 16

MON, OCT 19 • 12:30 PM ET

FORMAT

FIRESIDE CHAT

MODERATED, THEN QUESTIONS

LENGTH

30 MINUTES

VIRTUAL

YOUR TOPIC

Fundraising for concept to seed stage companies

DRAFT EVENT COPY

Written from your reply, not yet approved by you.
Correct anything wrong and send it back.

ABOUT THIS SESSION

Most fundraising advice on the internet is written for companies further along than the ones hearing it. Jonathan Hakakian invests at exactly the stage this cohort is at, concept to seed, and has run diligence on a portfolio of forty companies from outside the major city centers. A conversation about what actually gets an early company funded when it does not have the traction, the network or the zip code the playbook assumes.

TAKEAWAYS

Still to come from you. Three things a founder walks away able to do or decide, one line each. We can draft them from the conversation above if you would rather react to something than write from scratch.

WHO IT IS FOR

Founders raising or about to raise, and anyone deciding whether outside capital fits the company they are building.

ABOUT JONATHAN

In 2012 Jonathan co-founded SoundBoard Venture Fund with Richard Magid to build a community of experienced entrepreneurs to formally invest in early-stage companies outside the major city centers. He has raised capital for the fund, directed the diligence process into a growing portfolio of 40 companies, and coached many of the portfolio's entrepreneurs on their journeys. Jonathan is a fellow with the Kauffman Fellows Program, Class 19, where he focused his studies on being an innovative venture investor. He is an advisory board member for Miracle Corners of the World, judges entrepreneurship competitions, and received the NJBIZ 40 Under 40 award in the Entrepreneur category in 2018.

WHAT'S NEXT

Your date

We are holding Monday Oct 19 at 12:30 pending your reply. If another suits you better, these are open: Fri Sept 11 at 12:30 PM, Tue Sept 15 at 5:30 PM, Tue Sept 29 at 5:30 PM, Mon Oct 5 at 12:30 PM and 7 more. All Eastern.

Sync call

Book a prep call for the week before, whatever time works for you: calendly.com/mj-techunited/30min

Your 30 minutes

A 20 to 25 minute moderated conversation, then questions from founders at the end. Nothing to prepare and no deck. We hold the clock.

BILL NOONAN

Chief Business Development Officer, Choose New Jersey

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WHEN • TENTATIVELY SCHEDULED

SESSION 19

WED, OCT 21 • 12:30 PM ET

FORMAT

FIRESIDE CHAT

MODERATED BY AARON PRICE

LENGTH

30 MINUTES

VIRTUAL

YOUR TITLE

Still to come from you

OUR SUGGESTION

A fireside chat, moderated by **Aaron Price**, our CEO. No slides, no deck, nothing to prepare. The topic is the one thing still to pick, and Aaron would rather find it with you on a 15 minute call than hand you one.

WHAT IS SETTLED, AND WHAT IS NOT

Format and moderator are set.
The topic is the open question.

THE FORMAT, SETTLED

A fireside chat, moderated by Aaron Price, our CEO. You do not present, you do not build a deck, and there is nothing to prepare. Aaron asks, you answer, and founders put their own questions to you at the end.

ONE: YOUR TOPIC

The one thing still open, and Aaron would rather find it with you than assign it. Given what you do at Choose New Jersey, the cohort would get the most from the New Jersey side of building a company: what the state actually offers a growing business, how companies decide where to land and expand, and who is worth knowing. That is a room nobody else on our speaker list can fill. Bring an instinct to the call and Aaron will shape it with you.

TWO: YOUR THREE TAKEAWAYS

Three things a founder walks away able to do or decide. One line each is plenty, and these can come out of the call with Aaron too.

YOUR DATE

We are holding Wednesday Oct 21 at 12:30 pending your reply. If that does not work, these are open: Fri Sept 11 at 12:30 PM, Tue Sept 15 at 5:30 PM, Tue Sept 29 at 5:30 PM, Mon Oct 5 at 12:30 PM and 7 more. All Eastern.

ABOUT BILL

Bill Noonan is Chief Business Development Officer at Choose New Jersey, based in Newark. He is also a mentor in this fall's Uplift cohort, where he wrote that he wants to mentor startups because he understands the challenges of turning an innovative idea into a sustainable, growing business.

WHAT'S NEXT

Book the call with Aaron

Fifteen minutes with Aaron Price to land the topic. Any slot that works: calendly.com/mj-techunited/30min

Confirm the date

Reply yes to Wednesday Oct 21 and a new calendar hold goes out. The topic can follow after the call.

Your 30 minutes

A 20 to 25 minute conversation with Aaron, then questions from founders. We hold the clock.